OPERATION *VIJAY*, 1961

In 1947 Goa, Daman and Diu were still under Portuguese control, but it was not until 1961 that India decided to use military force to liberate them in a tri-service operation of which the recently formed 17 Infantry Division (less one brigade) and 50 (Independent) Parachute Brigade formed the land component. Opposing them were three Portuguese Army light-infantry battalions and a locally raised battalion with two artillery units. It was planned to launch simultaneous operations against all three colonies.

The Indian Army forces decided to conduct a multi-pronged offensive in Goa, with 50 (Independent) Parachute Brigade advancing from the north while 48 and 63 Infantry brigades advanced from the east; the objectives were Panjim and Mormugao. Simultaneously, the fictitious '20 Infantry Brigade' was to simulate an advance from the south. Diu was to be captured by 20 RAJPUT and a company of 4 MADRAS, while Daman was to be taken by 1 MARATHA LI. The Portuguese employed a strategy of sectoral defence with four battle groups tasked to engage, disrupt and delay the Indian columns and fall back in a coordinated manner.

The operations against Goa commenced on 17 December 1961 with the capture of the town of Maulinguem after a brief skirmish. The main offensive in Goa started at 0400hrs the next day, synchronized with the operations against Daman and Diu, which were concluded swiftly by 1100hrs on 18 December with Indian Navy and Indian Air Force (IAF) support. Leading the northern thrust in Goa, 50 (Independent) Parachute Brigade advanced in three columns and made contact with Portuguese troops north of Ponda and Mapuça by 1000hrs. There was no major engagement as the Portuguese withdrew after blowing up bridges to slow down the Indian advance. With no opposition, the brigade consolidated its gains and entered Panjim the next morning, but did not occupy Fort Aguada until later.

The progress of 63 Infantry Brigade was also unopposed but slow, with crossings having been destroyed by the withdrawing Portuguese. As a